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Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions

...for friends of AFS

Consider this situation: Sarah, an American teenager, and her family recently moved to Japan, where her father was transferred for work. Sarah is finding life in the big city of Tokyo a bit overwhelming, but she is trying to adjust and make friends. One of her biggest challenges has been school. There are many new rules and rituals – far more than she knew in the United States! For example, in Japan she must wear a uniform, while in the United States she did not. At her Japanese school, students not only wear the same uniform, but all the students in a given grade also wear the same shoes. Her classmates seem to like dressing the same as everyone else, but Sarah feels she has lost much of her ability to express herself. Another challenge for Sarah is that every day after class, all the students work together to clean their classroom and the school hallways. Sarah doesn't usually mind cleaning, but it is the last thing she wants to do after a long day at school, and she often feels frustrated and annoyed by the extra chore. Finally, the school year began with an hour-long ceremony. It was highly ritualized, and Sarah's classmates told her it was exactly the same year after year. Her classmates seemed to truly enjoy the ceremony, even though they had to stand for the full 60 minutes. Sarah was bored and tired from standing so long, and she could not understand why her classmates looked forward to this ceremony every year.



Being unable to navigate unfamiliar cultural settings can lead to frustration and confusion.

What is going on? Why do people from different cultures react differently to similar situations?

According to **Geert Hofstede**, cultural differences can explain this gap in behavior. When a foreigner like Sarah visits another country, he or she may feel out of place, uneasy or stressed because of how differently the locals act. These feelings can also come up when someone deals with people from other subcultures, as well as from other social classes, religions, genders and even other regions of their own country. But why do people from other cultures seem to act and think differently?

Geert Hofstede developed a theory that explains this, based on studies he carried out in the 1980s covering more than 50 national cultures. His theory is called **the Cultural Dimensions Theory**. It offers a framework for examining how cultural values affect behavior and gives clues as to why people from one culture may act in a certain way. The theory presents six Cultural Dimensions*: Power Distance, Individualism versus Collectivism, Uncertainty Avoidance, Masculinity versus Femininity, Long-Term Orientation, and Indulgence versus Restraint.

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- **The Cultural Dimensions are continuums, and many cultures fall between the two extremes. The cultural examples below do not mean that those cultures have every trait of that Cultural Dimension, only that they lean toward those traits.*

1. POWER DISTANCE INDEX (PDI)

The Power Distance Index (PDI) describes how far the less powerful members of a society accept and expect an unequal spread of power. In societies with high power distance, people do not question those at the top. They also expect the more powerful members to guide them. PDI is typically higher in societies in Asia, Eastern Europe, Latin America and Africa.

In cultures with low power distance, power is shared more equally among members, and moving up to a higher status (through education, income, job position, etc.) is possible. Some national cultures with low power distance are the Nordic countries, New Zealand and Australia.

Common traits of cultures with low and high Power Distance:

Low Power Distance	High Power Distance
Inequality is minimized	Inequality is accepted
Hierarchy exists for convenience	Hierarchy exists out of necessity
Superiors are approachable	Superiors are out of reach
Everyone has the same rights	Those in power have privileges
Change happens through gradual evolution	Change happens through revolution
Children are treated as equals	Children learn obedience

2. INDIVIDUALISM VERSUS COLLECTIVISM (IDV)

In an individualist society, people tend to make decisions on their own and look after themselves and their immediate family. Some individualist national cultures are the United States, Australia and England. In collectivist societies, on the other hand, group ties are strong, and family includes the extended family (aunts and uncles, cousins, etc.). Some collectivist national cultures are Guatemala, Pakistan and Indonesia.



In collectivist societies, relationships and group harmony are important.

Common traits of Collectivist and Individualist cultures:

Collectivism	Individualism
Focus on “we”	Focus on “I”
Relationships matter more than tasks	Stress on personal choice
Fulfill duties set by the group	Fulfill one's own duties

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Keep harmony, avoid direct confrontation	Speak one's mind directly
Communication is usually high-context	Communication is usually low-context

3. UNCERTAINTY AVOIDANCE INDEX (UAI)

The Uncertainty Avoidance Index (UAI) explains how people feel when dealing with unknown situations. In cultures with strong UAI, people tend to avoid risks and surprises. The unknown causes high anxiety and stress. Japan, Greece and Russia are countries whose national cultures have a high UAI, with a strong preference for predictable or controlled situations.

People in cultures with weak UAI tend to be more tolerant of what they cannot control. They accept uncertainty as part of life and are generally more relaxed and flexible in unfamiliar situations. Countries such as Jamaica and Singapore have national cultures that tend to accept ambiguity.

Common traits of strong and weak Uncertainty Avoidance:

Weak Uncertainty Avoidance	Strong Uncertainty Avoidance
Low stress about uncertainty	High stress about uncertainty
Uncertainty is part of daily life. People take things as they come	Uncertainty in life is a constant threat that must be fought
Differences of opinion are acceptable	There is a need for consensus
Taking risks is fine	There is a need to avoid failure
Little need for rules and laws	Great need for rules and laws

4. MASCULINITY VERSUS FEMININITY (MAS)



In masculine societies, the focus is on success and winning.

In societies with high Masculinity, competition and results drive people. People tend to be assertive and focused on material success. Countries with high-Masculinity national cultures include Japan, Venezuela, Italy, Ireland and Mexico.

In societies with low Masculinity, or Feminine societies, people focus on building good relationships and making sure everyone has a high quality of life. Being the best matters less, as long as everyone is happy. Countries with high-Femininity national cultures include Sweden, Norway, Finland, Denmark and the Netherlands.

Common traits of Feminine and Masculine cultures:

Feminine	Masculine
Focused on quality of life	Focused on ambition
Work to live	Live to work
Small and slow is beautiful	Big and fast is beautiful
Sympathy for the less fortunate	Admiration for success
Conflicts are settled through compromise and negotiation	Conflicts are settled by letting the strongest win

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5. LONG-TERM VERSUS SHORT-TERM ORIENTATION (LTO)

Societies with a long-term orientation encourage people to invest and to be thrifty. Persistence and caution pay off. Members of society hold different ranks, and elders must be respected.

Societies with a Long-Term Orientation also tend to adapt traditions to modern settings. East Asian countries such as China, Korea and Japan tend to have long-term oriented national cultures.

Societies with a Short-Term Orientation respect traditions but encourage spending and quick gains. A person's status matters less, and people value relationships only if they can gain something from them. The United States, England and Spain are some of the countries whose national cultures have a short-term orientation.



In the United States, long-term savings are often called a "nest egg."

Common traits of cultures with Long-Term and Short-Term Orientation:

Long-Term Orientation	Short-Term Orientation
Persistence and effort bring results slowly	Effort should bring quick results
Saving and caring for resources is important	There is social pressure to spend
Willing to put off one's own wishes for a good cause	Quick gains matter more than relationships

6. INDULGENCE VERSUS RESTRAINT (IVR)

This dimension looks at how much happiness and control over one's life matter. Societies with high Indulgence (high IVR) let people freely satisfy their needs and desires, especially those tied to enjoying life and having fun. In societies with high Restraint (low IVR), people hold back their urges under strict social norms. People hold moral discipline in high regard and tend to be more pessimistic.

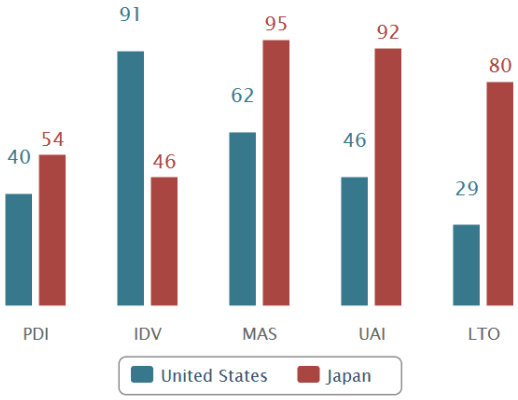
Common traits of Indulgence and Restraint cultures:

Indulgence (high IVR)	Restraint (low IVR)
Free behavior	Behavior is held back and regulated
Material rewards are not important	Material reward expected for work done
Focused on the present moment	Easily feels treated unfairly
Things are used for their usefulness, not for status	Things matter for status (car, house, company)
People are more positive and optimistic	People are more pessimistic and cynical
More outgoing and friendly	More reserved
Free time and friends are valued	Free time and friendships matter less

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Back to Our Case Study:

After reviewing Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions, let's think back on the incident described at the start of this document. **Can you apply the framework to Sarah's situation in Japan?**



Cultural Dimension comparisons for the U.S. and Japan, from http://geert-hofstede.com

Using Hofstede's data for each country, when we compare Japan and the United States, two dimensions with large differences bear on Sarah's story: Individualism versus Collectivism (IDV) and Uncertainty Avoidance (UAI). The United States, with an IDV score of 91 (out of 100), is a highly individualist society. This ties to the wish to express the unique traits of one's own identity and to focus on one's own needs rather than the needs of the group. Japan scores 46 on this dimension, which marks it as a collectivist society, where belonging to a group is important. Students show this membership through their uniforms and by taking part in group activities that serve the common good.

On Uncertainty Avoidance, Japan scores 92 and the United States 46. This shows that the Japanese generally prefer to avoid uncertainty and so enjoy structured, well-planned activities, while Americans have a high tolerance for the unknown. American activities are lively and constantly updated so as not to repeat what has already been done. These differences in group dealings, and in feelings about uncertainty, have caused Sarah much frustration.

As this scenario shows, when Cultural Dimensions differ, conflicts and/or misunderstandings can arise. Hofstede's six Cultural Dimensions are tools that let us make broad comparisons of cultures around the world. With them, we can understand a society's values and norms and why people's behavior may differ. Today, Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions theory is widely used in educational groups like AFS, workplaces, institutions and other intercultural settings to help their members understand each other in an international context.

Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions ...

- ☑ provide a framework of tendencies in behavior, outlook and values linked to 50 national cultures along the following dimensions:
    1. Power Distance (PDI)
    2. Individualism versus Collectivism (IDV)
    3. Masculinity versus Femininity (MAS)
    4. Uncertainty Avoidance (UAI)
    5. Long-Term Orientation (LTO)
    6. Indulgence versus Restraint (IVR)
- ☑ increase understanding of intercultural settings and of how people from different cultural backgrounds interact.

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